

SANIssoft Technologies



An Open Source Map that Leads to the Treasure!

'Show me the money?' is the question thrown at every open source entrepreneur who encourages fellow entrepreneurs to follow suit. Nagpur-based SANIssoft Technologies reveals some smart open source business tactics.

From college classrooms to office cafeterias and family dinner tables—Phunsukh Wangdu has been the topic of discussion ever since *3 Idiots* hit the box office. His saga of making it big from modest beginnings, coupled with his strong passion, boldness, and constant strive towards excellence left everyone in awe of him. We often bump into variants of Phunsukh Wangdu, but seldom realise it.

Entrepreneurs in the open source business, brimming with passion for free and open software, are Phunsukhs in the making. Their courage to open the source code of their products and solutions speaks for their confidence and focus on excellence. Yet, doubts remain on the feasibility of translating their passion into a commercially successful business. Tarique Sani, CTO of Nagpur-based SANIssoft Technologies, along with his wife, Swati Sani, erased all doubts on that front by building a viable business model around their Web development company, doing PHP programming with LAMP. Starting out small from Sani's house in 1998, SANIssoft grew 100

per cent, year-on-year, for the next five years, multiplying its revenue by 32 times.

"We began very small, with just our brains and one computer. Back then, the Internet as well as Web development was new to India. We didn't really do market research to see if we would fit in but just believed in our programming skills and sold our expertise," says Swati Sani, executive director, SANIssoft Technologies. Today, SANIssoft is growing at a rate of 40 per cent, year-on-year.

Building blocks

To create a niche for itself, SANIssoft's initial business strategy focused on selling solutions based on open source platforms rather than open source solutions, and that became its key differentiator. Further, the team focused on making the most of its team members' skills. While Tarique Sani, with 16 years of programming experience, focused on getting the solutions right, Swati Sani, who had been a communications specialist for nine years, managed the marketing. SANIssoft also contributed to open source initiatives. "We actively